SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

# Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

### Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

### Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

### Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The facts the kids check (shoe size, where you were, what you wore, how you feel about squishies) live on your **Suspect Statement form**, not in this video. The box at the top of your script gives you the four answers to write on the form, the one or two things the video has to agree with, and the lines to keep word for word. Everything else is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. Wear whatever you like. True details get the biggest laughs.

## The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached are your script and a one-page Suspect Statement form. The top of the script gives you four answers to copy onto the form so the kids' clues line up; the rest of the form is yours, and true is funnier. The video is a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video and the filled-in form by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 1 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 1

# VIDEO 1 — THE PRINCIPAL

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · The only interview with real information, and it arrives by accident. Deadpan. Hold the beats.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 1 · THE PRINCIPAL · 9:12 AM

**MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)**

- On your Suspect Statement form, write these four exactly (the kids check them against evidence): Q1 yesterday afternoon: "Off campus at a meeting, 1:00 to 3:00. A meeting about the next meeting." Q3 shoe size: 9. Q4 wearing: "An orange sweater. Halloween spirit." Q5 squishies: tick LOVE THEM, "I own ONE. It's a cat. It's for stress." Answer everything else however you like; true is funnier. Hand the form in with your video.
- On camera only two things have to agree with the form: you were off campus at a meeting all afternoon (that is what clears you, so don't say a time on camera), and you own exactly one squishy, [a cat]. Want a different squishy? Change it on the form too, and tell the room parent.
- Must match the real jar: "the big one, on the high shelf [by the window], with [three] strips of tape." Describe the actual jar in the actual spot.
- Free to change: [four minutes], the kind of meeting, [tie or collar], what the squishy is for. Add one true detail about yourself; it lands harder.
- Keep exactly: saying "squishies" by accident, then "candy," then trying to un-say it. That slip is the whole party.

**Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.**

*(Sit. Look just beside the camera. Check your watch.)*

I have a meeting in [four minutes], so let's make this quick.

You want to know where I was yesterday afternoon. I was in a meeting. Off campus. I'm always in a meeting. Yesterday it was a meeting about the next meeting.

And you want to know what I know about the missing candy. Let me be very clear about this. I have not heard ANYTHING, and I know NOTHING, about anyone stealing the squishies.

***(beat)***

I mean candy.

***(beat)***

...Did I say squishies? What was I thinking! Candy. The candy. I know nothing about the candy.

***(pause. Straighten your [tie or collar].)***

I did not say squishies. I may have said squishies. It's a very common word. People say it all the time. In meetings. I am the principal of this school. I say a lot of words every day. Statistically, some of them are going to be "squishies."

*(too fast)*

And for the record, I have never even seen that jar. The big one. On the high shelf [by the window]. With the [three] strips of tape on the lid and the label that says "do not open."

*(realize what you just said)*

...Which I can only describe because people have described it to me. In meetings.

***(pause)***

Do I own any squishies myself? I'm the principal.

***(beat)***

...One. It's [a cat]. It's on my desk. It's for stress. This is stressful. (look at watch) I'm late.

*(Stand up and walk out of frame. Leave the phone recording for 3 more seconds, then say, from off camera, slightly muffled:)*

Is it off? Did it get the squishy thing? ...Can we cut the squishy thing?

*(Then stop recording.)*

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031

# Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

**Name** _____ **Job at this school** _____

**1. Where were you yesterday afternoon? Give times.**

_____

_____

**2. Who can confirm that?**

_____

**3. Shoe size** (we will check) _____ **4. What were you wearing yesterday?** Color counts. _____

**5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?**

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

**6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?**

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define "inside" _____

**7. Did you take the Jar?**

_____

**8. Anything else the detectives should know?**

_____

_____

_____

**Signature** _____ **Date** _____

**OFFICIAL USE ONLY**

Cleared by: ☐ Clue 1 footprint ☐ Clue 2 timeline ☐ Clue 3 orange sweater ☐ Clue 4 witness